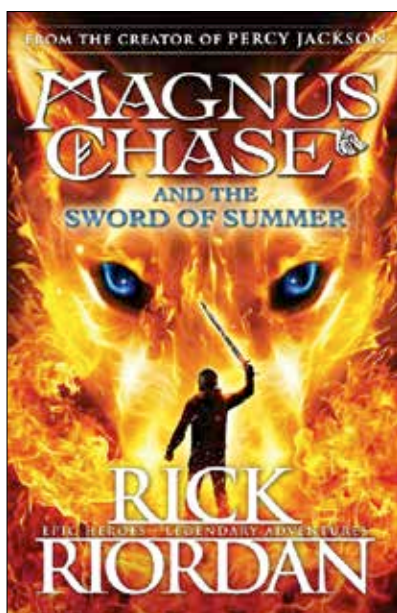


COMEDY/ADVENTURE/
MYTHOLOGY

Magnus Chase and the Sword of the Summer

★★★★☆ | *Okay, we know this is not something very new. But hey... books don't expire so here we are!* With a very distinctive writing style, Rick Riordan is mostly known for his debut book series, Percy Jackson and the Gods of Olympus. Famously known to unravel fantastic teenage demigods adventures, these books are cleverly spun with mythological characters and gods in close ties with the modern world. In general, each of these series usually follow a specific mythology and abide by its respective settings, traits and characters. The Magnus Chase and the Gods of Asgard series is a similar addition, set on Norse mythology and depicting how the pro-



tagonist voyages through challenges to delay the 'Ragnarok' doomsday. Along the way he even encounters several renowned Norse gods like Thor, Loki, Frey, Freya, Mimir and many more.

Like Percy Jackson, the series follows the narration by the protagonist

himself. Set in Boston, USA, Magnus Chase is briefly introduced at the beginning of the book as a character who is almost 16 and has been homeless for over two years.

He does have what remains of his largely stretching family, but he does not trust them. Especially after his mother warned him not to put any faith in his uncle. The story moves on, and the author does an excellent job of keeping us hooked throughout. Altogether it is a great adventure read for teenagers. There is also emphasis and usage of different cultures. How two people from the same world can have different opinions - their thoughts might clash but they teach each other a lot of new things as well. Besides that, Magnus is a witty fellow and makes lots of snarky comments to ensure that the book never becomes too serious. It is a feast for a fantasy lover with diverse and flamboyant characters, hilarious adventures and rarely a dull moment while reading through.

—Nayan Panda

HORROR
FICTION

Locke and Key: The Golden Age review

★★★★☆ | If there's one book that could be classified as a true adult-oriented fantasy, Locke and Key would be it. Written exclusively by Joe Hill and illustrated by Gabriel Rodriguez, Locke and Key charts the story of the Locke family through various ages as they combat extra-dimensional entities using magical keys. The latest in the series, The Golden Age, is a collection of tales that precede the events of the main story. Set in the early 20th century, The Golden Age takes us through the killing fields of WW1 and the prohibition era, giving us a glimpse into the early ancestors of the Lockes and their struggles with the all-powerful keys.



Locke and Key takes familiar fantasy tropes and twists them until they're completely unrecognizable. There's something dangerous about Keyhouse and the Lockes are truly tested, whether it's by familial illness or demonic entities. In fact, there are a few nods to DC fans

with a few cameos by the Endless in The Golden Age. If you haven't checked out the original series, it might be a little difficult for you to really get what's going on, so we'd recommend you back and check out the OG series before reading The Golden Age. The stories will make much more sense then. But, if you can't really get your hands on the original series, The Golden Age still contains some of the best fantasy stories that we've read this year.

Just like his father Stephen King, Joe Hill weaves a yarn that is equal parts compelling, action-packed and emotionally weighty. The Lockes feel like a real family, complete with all the dirty laundry that inevitably comes with tight, unshakable bonds. The winding tale is complemented by the precise and expressive artwork of Gabriel Rodriguez. As a former architect, Rodriguez's Keyhouse just feels real and lived in. There's a weight to his work that gives the story its gravitas. If you're looking for a book that will take you on a real journey, you should pick up Locke and Key: The Golden Age.

—Andrew Lu